



Cimply — Competitive Brief 1: Scheduling Tools

Writing sample — Cimply is a demonstration scheduling product for creative studios, built to showcase documentation and product-strategy writing skills. Not a live commercial product.

Competitive data (pricing, features, positioning) reflects research conducted in June 2026 and is illustrative for this writing sample, not current market intelligence. A companion brief, “Competitive Brief 2: Horizontal Platforms,” covers monday.com, ClickUp, and Notion as a separate sales-objection angle.

Competitive Landscape Overview

Cimply operates at the intersection of two categories: resource scheduling and work management. No single existing tool owns both for small creative studios. This gap is Cimply’s primary opportunity.

The competitive set falls into three tiers:

- **Direct competitors** — purpose-built scheduling tools for agencies: Float, Resource Guru.
- **Adjacent competitors** — full project management platforms with scheduling components: Teamwork.
- **Substitute solutions** — what small studios actually use today: Google Calendar + Slack + spreadsheets (the DIY stack).

Competitor Overviews

Float

Founded: 2012 | Target market: Creative agencies, in-house production teams, professional services | Customers: 4,500+ agencies globally

Float positions itself as a resource scheduling and time tracking tool. Its core product is a drag-and-drop visual calendar that shows who is working on what and when. It has expanded into project estimation and financial reporting, targeting agencies that want to connect capacity planning to profitability.

Pricing: \$7/user/month (Starter) · \$12/user/month (Pro) · Enterprise custom

Recent momentum: Added an Estimates feature connecting resource scheduling to project budgeting. Targeting upmarket with financial reporting capabilities.

Resource Guru

Founded: 2012 | Target market: Digital agencies, consultancies, IT teams | Customers: 60,000+ users including NASA, Ogilvy, CNN



Resource Guru positions on simplicity — a fast, clean scheduling tool for teams moving off spreadsheets. It covers people, equipment, and rooms. Its pitch is speed of onboarding and clarity of interface over depth of features.

Pricing: \$4.16/user/month (Grasshopper) · \$6.65/user/month (Blackbelt) · \$10/user/month (Master)

Recent momentum: SOC 2 Type II compliance, signaling an enterprise push. Competing primarily on price and ease of use.

Teamwork

Founded: 2007 | Target market: Agencies managing client work and billing | Customers: Agencies and professional services firms

Teamwork is a full project management platform built around client-facing agency work — client portals, time tracking, budget management, and invoicing. It is broader than Cimply’s scope by design, serving the project-to-invoice workflow rather than the internal scheduling and execution layer.

Pricing: \$10.99/user/month (annual) · \$29.99/user/month (Accelerate) · Enterprise custom · Free plan (up to 5 users, 5 projects)

Recent momentum: AI features, financial tracking tied to time entries, and stronger client collaboration tools. Moving upmarket.

The DIY Stack (Google Calendar + Slack + Spreadsheets)

Cost: Effectively free (tools already in use)

The most common “solution” at small studios is no dedicated tool at all. Schedulers manage capacity in a shared Google Calendar, communicate job details in Slack threads, and track work in a spreadsheet. This is the status quo Cimply is displacing — not a product, but a behavior.

Why it persists: Zero switching cost, familiar tools, no new software to justify. Small studios often do not realize the overhead they’re absorbing until it becomes painful.

Feature Comparison

Capability	Cimply (v1)	Float	Resource Guru	Teamwork	DIY Stack
Scheduling					
Resource assignment	Strong	Strong	Strong	Adequate	Weak
Drag-and-drop calendar view	Absent (v1)	Strong	Strong	Adequate	Absent
Availability / capacity view	P1	Strong	Strong	Adequate	Weak
Equipment / room scheduling	Absent (by design)	Absent	Strong	Absent	Weak
Work Orders					
Work brief / instructions on assignment	Strong	Weak	Weak	Adequate	Weak
Order lifecycle / status tracking	Strong	Absent	Absent	Adequate	Absent
Two-sided in-order messaging	Strong	Absent	Absent	Adequate	Weak



Capability	Cimply (v1)	Float	Resource Guru	Teamwork	DIY Stack
Designer-facing task queue	Strong	Adequate	Adequate	Adequate	Absent
Time					
Time actualization / logging	Strong	Strong	Absent	Strong	Weak
Comparison of estimated vs. actual hours	P1	Strong	Absent	Strong	Absent
Admin / Reporting					
Scheduler dashboard (team view)	Strong	Strong	Strong	Strong	Weak
Filtering by designer and status	Strong	Strong	Adequate	Strong	Absent
Utilization / capacity reporting	Absent	Strong	Adequate	Strong	Absent
Financial / billing reporting	Absent (by design)	Adequate	Absent	Strong	Absent
UX / Access					
Mobile app	Absent (P2)	Adequate	Weak	Adequate	Adequate
Email notification on assignment	Strong	Adequate	Adequate	Adequate	N/A
Setup complexity	Low	Medium	Low	High	Low
Price per user/month	TBD	\$7–12	\$4–10	\$11–30	~\$0

Rating scale: Strong / Adequate / Weak / Absent

Positioning Analysis

Float

“The resource management and time tracking tool that helps your team do their best work.”

- **Category claim:** Resource management + time tracking
- **Differentiator:** Visual clarity, financial reporting connection
- **Value proposition:** See who is doing what so you can plan and bill confidently
- **Target:** Agencies that want capacity planning tied to profitability

Resource Guru

“The resource scheduling tool that’s fast to set up and easy to use.”

- **Category claim:** Resource scheduling
- **Differentiator:** Simplicity and speed of onboarding
- **Value proposition:** Get off spreadsheets without the setup pain
- **Target:** Teams that need basic scheduling without complexity

Teamwork

“The only project management platform built for client work.”

- **Category claim:** Project management for agencies
- **Differentiator:** Client-to-invoice workflow, financial visibility
- **Value proposition:** Run your agency from project kickoff to client billing



- **Target:** Agencies managing multiple clients who need financial oversight

Cimply (proposed)

“The work order tool for creative teams — so designers know exactly what to do and schedulers always know where things stand.”

- **Category claim:** Work order management (not just scheduling)
- **Differentiator:** The order as a living document — brief, communication, status, and time record in one place
- **Value proposition:** Replace the Slack thread + spreadsheet combo with one place where work gets done
- **Target:** Small creative studios (agencies, in-house teams) where a scheduler manages a team of staff designers

Strengths and Weaknesses

Float

Strengths: Best-in-class visual calendar. Strong time tracking and financial reporting. Well-known brand in the agency space. Integrations with common tools.

Weaknesses: No work brief or instructions model — assignment is just a calendar block. No in-product communication between scheduler and designer. Mobile app is clunky. Reporting customization is limited. Can feel expensive for small teams using only basic features.

Resource Guru

Strengths: Lowest price entry point. Fastest onboarding in the category. Clean, simple interface. Handles equipment and rooms (useful for studios with shared resources). SOC 2 compliant.

Weaknesses: Very limited feature depth — essentially a calendar with names on it. No work brief, no communication, no time logging. Reporting is weak. Interface density complaints from larger teams. No real designer-facing experience — it’s entirely scheduler-centric.

Teamwork

Strengths: Broadest feature set in the category. Strong client collaboration and billing tools. Good for agencies that need project-to-invoice. Time tracking is mature.

Weaknesses: Overkill for small internal teams not managing client billing. High setup complexity. Expensive for a 5–8 person studio. Designed around client-facing project management, not internal resource scheduling. Designer experience is generic task management, not purpose-built.

DIY Stack

Strengths: Free. Already in use. No new tool to learn or justify. Flexible.

Weaknesses: Work details live in Slack threads that get buried. No single view of what is in progress. No order lifecycle — no one knows where a job stands without asking. No time logging tied to the work. Context is lost every time someone asks “what’s the status on that logo?”



Opportunities

- **The work order gap is real and unoccupied at this tier.** Float and Resource Guru both treat an assignment as a calendar block — a name on a time slot. Neither has a model for the brief, the back-and-forth, the status lifecycle, or the time record. Cimplify's order model is differentiated by design, not by incremental feature addition.
- **The designer experience is an afterthought in every competing tool.** Float and Resource Guru are built for schedulers. Designers get a read-only calendar view if they're lucky. Cimplify's designer-first queue — “here is what you need to do, here is everything you need to know, here is where you ask questions” — is a genuine differentiator.
- **Small studios are underserved.** Float is pricing toward mid-market agencies that care about financial reporting. Resource Guru is adding enterprise compliance. Teamwork targets client-billing agencies. Nobody is specifically building for the 3–15 person creative studio that just needs to manage internal work clearly. That is Cimplify's beachhead.
- **The DIY stack switcher is the primary acquisition target.** Studios using Google Calendar + Slack + spreadsheets are not evaluating Float — they do not think they have a “scheduling problem” yet. Cimplify's positioning should speak to the symptom (“how many times did you have to Slack someone to find out where that project stood?”) not the category.

Threats

- **Float could add a brief/notes model.** The gap between “assignment as calendar block” and “assignment as work order” is not technically complex. If Float adds a robust notes + messaging layer to assignments, the differentiation narrows. Monitor their changelog closely.
- **Resource Guru's price is hard to undercut on pure scheduling.** If small studios just want to see who's available, Resource Guru at \$4/user/month is a tough value argument to beat. Cimplify needs the order model to justify its price point — if studios don't value the brief and communication layer, they will not pay a premium for it.
- **monday.com and ClickUp are omnipresent.** Both are aggressively targeting agencies with flexible templates. A studio could build a passable “work order” workflow in either tool without buying Cimplify. The risk is good enough, not better — and both tools have massive marketing budgets.
- **The DIY stack has zero switching cost.** The biggest competitive threat is inertia. Small studios tolerate a lot of pain before they buy new software. Cimplify's onboarding needs to be fast enough that a scheduler can have their first order created and assigned within 10 minutes of signing up.



Strategic Implications for Cimply v1

1. **Lead with the order, not the calendar.** Every competitor leads with a calendar view. Cimply's differentiator is the order — make that the hero of the product. The dashboard leads with the order queue, not a Gantt chart.
2. **Price between Resource Guru and Float.** A \$6–8/user/month price point positions Cimply above the bare-bones scheduling tier but below the full project management tier. It signals “more than a calendar, less than an agency suite.” Validate this in beta.
3. **Designer experience is a sales tool.** When pitching Cimply to a scheduler, show them the designer's screen. “This is what your designer sees when they log in” is a compelling demo moment that no competitor can match. Make it beautiful.
4. **Target the DIY stack switcher first.** Marketing should speak to small studios that do not use dedicated scheduling software — not studios evaluating Float. The conversion message: “still scheduling in Google Calendar and answering status questions in Slack? There's a better way.”
5. **Keep v1 scope tight.** Float and Resource Guru win on breadth of scheduling features (drag-and-drop, capacity utilization, equipment). Do not try to match them. Win on depth of the order workflow. A studio that values the brief + communication + status + time record in one place will not miss the drag-and-drop calendar.
6. **Monitor Float's product roadmap.** They are the most capable direct competitor and the most likely to close the work order gap. Watch their changelog, blog, and job postings for signals of a communication or work-brief feature.

What to Monitor

Signal	Why it matters	How often
Float changelog and blog	Most likely to add brief/messaging to assignments	Monthly
Resource Guru pricing changes	They set the floor for the category	Quarterly
monday.com / ClickUp agency templates	“Good enough” alternatives with huge reach	Quarterly
G2 / Capterra reviews mentioning “communication” or “brief”	Reveals unmet demand Cimply can target	Monthly
Agency job postings for “studio coordinator” or “resource manager”	Signals growing need for dedicated scheduling roles	Quarterly

Research conducted June 14, 2026. Competitive landscapes shift quickly — pricing and feature claims should be verified before reuse in any live sales or investor context.

Sources

Float: [GetApp](#), [G2](#), [Capterra](#), [The Digital Project Manager](#)



Resource Guru: [The Digital Project Manager](#), [People Managing People](#), [Capterra](#)

Teamwork: [Capterra](#), [The Digital Project Manager](#)

Category context: [Workamajig](#), [The Digital Project Manager — Creative PM Software](#), [The Digital Project Manager — Resource Scheduling Tools](#)